The Wind in the Willows

A simplified retelling

Original story by Kenneth Grahame

The same journey. Clearer, shorter English.

Abridged and retold for Speak Boldly Intermediate reading practice

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1. Beyond the front door

Mole was tired of spring-cleaning. Above his underground home, the world was waking up. He put down his brush, climbed outside and went exploring.

At the river, he met Water Rat, who invited him into a boat. Mole had never seen the river before. Rat seemed to know its every mood, from quiet backwaters to busy little currents.

They shared a picnic and began a friendship. Mole was eager to learn, though his enthusiasm sometimes ran ahead of his skill. When he tried to manage the boat too soon, he overturned it. Rat helped him rather than ending the friendship over a mistake.

Mole stayed beside the river and discovered a life he had never imagined. He also heard about the Wild Wood, where strangers had to be careful, and about Badger, who preferred a quieter kind of company.

Then Rat introduced him to Toad, who had an impressive house and a new enthusiasm almost every time they met.

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2. Toad’s latest passion

Toad wanted Rat and Mole to travel with him in a horse-drawn caravan. He described the open road as the finest life imaginable. They agreed to go.

On the journey, a motorcar rushed past and frightened the horse. The caravan was damaged. Rat was angry, but Toad could hardly speak. He had discovered something more exciting than caravans.

Soon he was buying motorcars, driving recklessly and crashing them. Each accident cost money, and each warning seemed to make little difference. Toad liked the feeling of speed more than he disliked the consequences.

His friends worried about him. They could see that his freedom was being used to place himself and others in danger. Toad heard their concern as an attempt to spoil his pleasure.

Rat and Mole returned to the river. Friendship with Toad was enjoyable, but it was becoming difficult to separate his company from the disasters that followed him.

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3. The Wild Wood

Mole decided to visit Badger by himself. In the Wild Wood, the light faded and the paths became confusing. Strange faces seemed to watch him. He was lost and frightened.

Rat noticed his absence and went searching. He found Mole, but snow made their journey home difficult. At last, they discovered a door beneath the drifts. It was Badger’s home.

Inside were warmth, food and a host whose quiet manner concealed real generosity. Mole learned that welcoming someone did not always require cheerful conversation. Sometimes it meant giving them dry clothes and a place to rest.

On another journey, Mole smelled his own old home and became unexpectedly homesick. Rat initially hurried on, then understood. They returned together. The modest rooms were dusty, but Mole was proud to offer what he had. With help from visiting field mice, the evening became a celebration.

The river had enlarged Mole’s world without making his

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first home worthless.

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4. Things that pull you away

When Otter’s little son Portly disappeared, Rat and Mole searched along the water. In the quiet of early morning, they found him in a place that felt strangely protected. For a moment, they sensed a mysterious, comforting presence in the natural world. Then the memory faded, leaving them with the child safely returned.

Later, Rat met a travelling sea rat whose stories awakened an intense desire to leave. Suddenly, the familiar river seemed too small. He prepared to follow the stranger towards distant places.

Mole persuaded him to pause and remain with him. Rest and writing gradually helped Rat recover his own balance.

Adventure could be wonderful, but an exciting voice could also make someone forget what he already valued. Mole had learned from Rat; now he could help him in return.

Their concern for Toad, meanwhile, was becoming urgent. Badger agreed that they had to act.

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5. Toad loses his freedom

The friends stayed at Toad Hall and tried to stop Toad driving. He promised to change, then pretended to be ill so that he could escape Rat’s watch.

At an inn, he saw an unattended motorcar. Desire overcame every warning. He stole it, drove away and was arrested. His insults and reckless conduct helped bring a severe prison sentence.

In prison, Toad felt sorry for himself. The gaoler’s daughter pitied him and helped him escape disguised as a washerwoman. He was grateful, but soon found that disguise did not solve every problem.

Without money, he depended on help and invented stories. He caught a train, quarrelled with a barge-woman and was thrown into the canal. Even after all this, another chance to drive a car nearly carried him into fresh disaster.

When he finally reached Rat’s home, he was wet, exhausted and still tempted to describe his troubles as a series of heroic adventures.

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6. The return to Toad Hall

Badger had news. While Toad was away, weasels and stoats had taken over Toad Hall. They were living noisily in it and refusing to leave.

Toad wanted an immediate attack. Badger preferred a plan. He knew a secret passage that led from the riverbank into the house. During a celebration, the four friends entered by that route and surprised the occupiers.

Together, they drove them out and restored the house. Toad could not honestly claim to have achieved the victory alone.

He still wanted to make speeches about himself and sing songs of his own greatness. His friends insisted on a more modest celebration. This time, he tried to listen.

Toad thanked people who had helped him and began treating his neighbours more considerately. Changing did not mean becoming Rat, Mole or Badger. It meant discovering that being himself was no excuse for making everyone else manage the damage.

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By the river, the friendships continued. Mole had found adventure outside his door, and something steadier within it: people who would welcome him, challenge him and help him find his way home.

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Words to keep

Backwater — a quiet stretch of water away from the main current. Rat knew the river’s backwaters.

Enthusiasm — eager interest or excitement. Toad’s enthusiasm changed frequently.

Reckless — careless about danger or consequences. His reckless driving caused crashes.

Disguise — something that changes how a person appears. Toad escaped in a disguise.

Modest — not showing off or claiming too much importance. His friends encouraged a modest celebration.

Hospitality — welcoming and caring for guests. Badger showed hospitality through practical help.

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A question to carry with you

What is the difference between a friend who supports you and a friend who agrees with everything you do?

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